

Technical Communication in the Workplace

Chapter 1

TECHNICAL DOCUMENTS

Correspondence

Memos to your boss and to your
Routine letters to customers, vendors etc
Letters to customers
Sales letters to potential customers
Electronic mail to co-workers or customers

Short Reports

Analysis of problem
Recommendation
Equipment Evaluation
Progress or periodic report
Description of results of a laboratory work or a company trip

Long Reports

Project report in field or laboratory work
Proposal and Feasibility study

Other Examples

Abstract or summary of technical articles
Technical article or presentation
Operation manual
Website

Technical storytelling - Not writing...

Explaining complex technical ideas to:

- Executives
- Clients
- engineers
- Investors
- non-technical users
- Colleagues

The most valuable engineers are no longer those who merely produce text.

They are those who can:

- recognise misinformation
- communicate uncertainty
- explain technical ideas to non-technical audiences
- evaluate AI-generated content
- persuade stakeholders
- negotiate trade-offs
- and maintain trust through clear, ethical communication

Sample Technical Documents

MEMORANDUM

DATE: December 6, 2011
TO: Holly Newsome
FROM: Michael Allen
SUBJECT: Printer Recommendation

Introductory Summary

Recently you asked for my evaluation of the Hemphill 5000 printer/fax/scanner/copier currently used in my department. Having analyzed the machine's features, print quality, and cost, I am quite satisfied with its performance.

Features

Among the Hemphill 5000's features, I have found these five to be the most useful:

1. Easy-to-use control panel
2. Print and copy speed of up to 34 pages per minute for color and black-and-white
3. Ability to print high-quality documents like brochures & report covers
4. Built-in networking capability
5. Ability to scan documents to or from a USB port

In addition, the Hemphill 5000 offers high-quality copies, color copies, and faxes, and it uses high-capacity ink cartridges to reduce costs.

Print Quality

The Hemphill 5000 produces excellent prints that rival professional typeset quality. The print resolution is 1200 x 1200 dots per inch, among the highest attainable in combination printer/fax/scanner/copiers. This memo was printed on the 5000, and as you can see, the quality speaks for itself.

Cost

Considering the features and quality, the 5000 is an excellent network combination printer for work groups within the firm. At a retail price of \$239, it is also one of the lowest-priced combination printers, yet it comes with a two-year warranty and excellent customer support.

Conclusion

On the basis of my observation, I strongly recommend that our firm continue to use and purchase the Hemphill 5000. Please call me at ext. 204 if you want further information about this excellent machine.



Use a Programmable Thermostat Properly

A programmable thermostat is ideal for people who are away from home during set periods of time throughout the week. Through proper use of pre-programmed settings, a programmable thermostat can save you about \$180 every year in energy costs.

Overview information summarizes the document's main point

How Do You Choose the Right One for You?

Heading is phrased as the main question readers will ask

To decide which model is best for you, think about your schedule and how often you are away from home for regular periods of time—work, school, other activities—and then decide which of the three different models best fits your schedule:

7-day models are best if your daily schedule tends to change; for example, if children are at home earlier on some days. These models give you the most flexibility and let you set different programs for different days—usually with four possible temperature periods per day.

Paragraphs and sentences are short

5+2-day models use the same schedule every weekday, and another for weekends.

Color is used to highlight key items

5-1-1 models are best if you tend to keep one schedule Monday through Friday and another schedule on Saturdays and Sundays.

Programmable Thermostat Settings

You can use the table below as a starting point for setting energy-saving temperatures, and then adjust the settings to fit your family's schedule and stay comfortable.

Setting	Time	Setpoint Temperature (Heat)	Setpoint Temperature (Cool)
Wake	6:00 a.m.	< 70° F	> 78° F
Day	8:00 a.m.	Setback at least 8° F	Setup at least 7° F
Evening	6:00 p.m.	< 70° F	> 78° F
Sleep	10:00 p.m.	Setback at least 8° F	Setup at least 4° F

Table provides easy-to-read comparative data

ABOUT THE HEART TRUTH®

To make women more aware of the danger of heart disease, the National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute (NHLBI) is sponsoring a national program called *The Heart Truth*®, in partnership with many national and community organizations. The program's goal is to raise awareness about heart disease and its risk factors among women and educate and motivate them to take action to prevent the disease and control its risk factors.

National Symbol

The centerpiece of *The Heart Truth* is the *Red Dress*®, which was introduced as the national symbol for women and heart disease awareness in 2002 by the NHLBI. The *Red Dress*® reminds women of the need to protect their heart health and inspires them to take action to lower their risk for the disease.

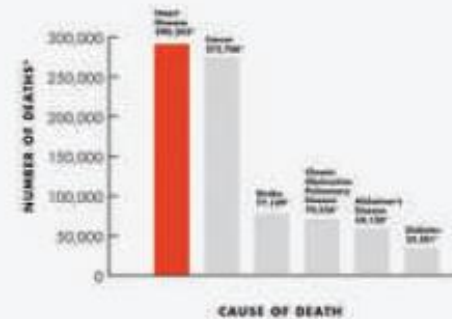
Program Objectives

Primary Objectives

1. Increase awareness that heart disease is the leading cause of death among women.
2. Increase awareness of the risk factors for heart disease.
3. Increase awareness that having risk factors can lead to heart disease, disability, and death.
4. Increase perceived susceptibility to heart disease (e.g. an individual's perception

LEADING CAUSES OF DEATH FOR AMERICAN WOMEN (2010)

Of the women who died in 2010, one in four women died from heart disease. It's the #1 killer of women. It strikes at younger ages than most people think, and the risk rises in middle age.



To learn more, visit www.hearttruth.gov.

*Numbers of deaths are based on the most recent data available and rounded to the nearest tenth.

*National Vital Statistics System, Underlying Cause of Death on CDC Wonder Online Database

The Heart Truth, its logo and The Red Dress are registered trademarks of NHLBI.



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Features	Purpose	Writer's Knowledge of Topic	Audience	Criteria of Evaluation	Graphic Elements
Academic Writing	Communicating what the student knows about the topic to earn a high grade	Less than the teacher who evaluates the writing	The teacher who assigned the project or classmates	Depth, logic, clarity, unity, supporting evidence, and grammar	Sometimes used to explain and persuade
Workplace Writing	Getting something done within an organization	Usually more than the reader's knowledge	Often several people with differing professional backgrounds	Clear content organization, appropriate to the needs of busy readers	Frequently used to help readers find information and understand ideas

Organizational culture includes:

- history
- leadership
- values
- power structure
- decision-making
- communication norms

rather than simply "*company traditions*"

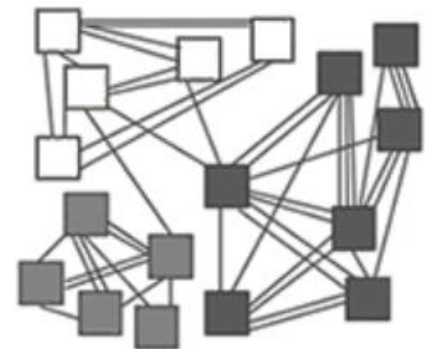
Understanding Cultures

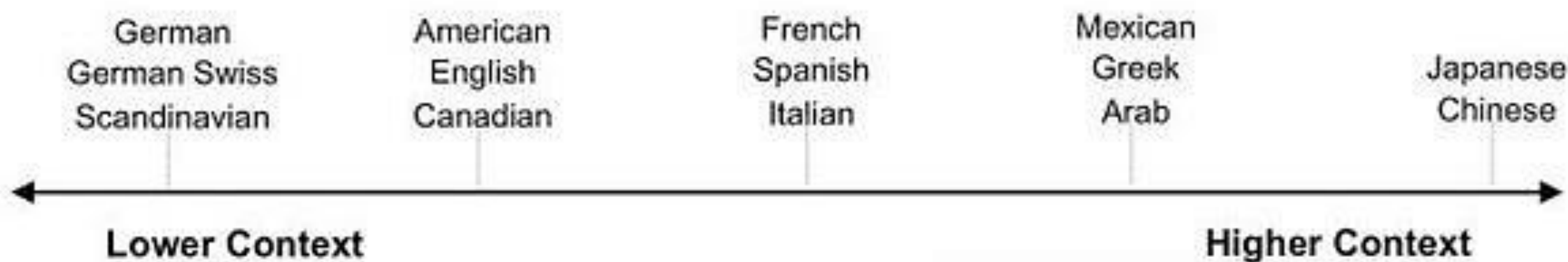
High-context Culture

- Fairly homogeneous, with the culture providing a high degree of context for communication. Thus, communications may be less explicit because members of the culture share characteristics such as religion, ethnic background, and education.
- Important characteristics:**
 - Clear distinctions between insiders and outsiders
 - A focus on maintaining relationships, on saving face, and on helping others save face
 - A dependence on internalized cultural norms to govern behavior.

Low-context Culture

- consist of diverse religions, ethnic backgrounds, and educational levels; as a result, communication must be explicit, because members of a group cannot assume that they share knowledge or attitudes. The culture provides a low degree of context for communication. The United States is an example of a low-context culture.
- Important characteristics:**
 - Openness to outsiders
 - A focus on actions and solving problems, with a willingness to disagree openly
 - A dependence on formally established rules to govern behavior





Low Context

Communication:

- Specific
- Detailed
- Precise

Poorer at decoding:

- Unspoken message
- Body language

High Context

Communication:

- Less direct

Emphasis on:

- Human relations

More sensitivity to:

- Non-verbals
- Feelings of others

Cultural Differences

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Big picture vs. details	High-context vs. Low-context
Order vs. chaos	Monochronic vs. Polychronic
Formal vs. informal	Top-down communication vs. back and forth and up and down
Motivations and rewards	Personal achievement vs. financial rewards
Quality vs. quantity of decisions	methodical process
Giving and receiving feedback	Negative vs. positive feedback
Expressing opinions	Openly disagree
Role of managers	Egalitarianism vs. hierarchy
Willingness to sacrifice personal time	forgo personal time if needed.

Basic Ethical Principles

- Honesty
- Avoiding harm
- Fairness
- Respect for confidentiality
- Professionalism

Ethical Writing Framework

